

FAILING MARX

KERALA

There was a time when they believed that communism was the only gospel and Marx the prophet. Today's Marxists are cast in a different mould. The CPI(M) in Kerala finds nothing odd in taking orders from a cleric. Abdul Nasser Madani heads the People's Democratic Party (PDP) and is not even a member of the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) but the CPI(M), bowing to his diktat, will field an independent candidate for the Ponnani Lok Sabha seat in north Kerala. They have even begun campaigning for him—a non-political Islamic scholar—even as the CPI, which had earlier held the seat, cries foul. Across the political fence, the Congress is under pressure from the powerful Syro-Malabar Catholic Church to field Tom Vadakkan, a little-known secretary in the AICC, from Thrissur while the local Congress shrieks in protest. So strong is the hold of religious groups on the national and secular parties that the CPI(M) has cold-shouldered the CPI's protest while the Congress has suspended local leaders who opposed Vadakkan's candidature.

The CPI(M)'s zeal to placate the PDP and other Muslim groups like the Jamaat-e-Islami or Samasta, a Sunni clerics' organisation, is aimed at defeating the Muslim League in its bastion Ponnani. It had for the first time successfully tried out the combined opposition to the Muslim League in Malappuram district in the last Assembly polls when League stalwarts like P.K. Kunhalikutty and M.K. Muneer, among others, had been trounced. The Government's decision to give pensions to madrasa teachers and set up an off-campus centre of Aligarh Muslim University in Malappuram has also endeared the Left to the Muslim community, which forms 22 per cent of the state's 3.1 crore population. Sensing danger, Muslim League's E. Ahamed, Union minister of state for external affairs, has shifted from his traditional Ponnani seat to a safer Malappuram for the upcoming elections.

It has become crucial for the CPI(M) to woo the Muslims as the Christian leaders have declared open war against the Left. The Catholic

Church has even called upon Christians to defeat the Left in the polls. The church's biggest complaint is against Marxist Education Minister M.A. Baby, a Catholic himself, who has initiated many moves to bring in regulations in the higher education sector dominated by the Church. The Catholic Church has also castigated the latest Left moves to ally with the Biju Janata Dal of Orissa, which it considers responsible for the anti-Christian incidents of violence last year.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan



Second Shot For THIRD FRONT

As an electoral show of strength, it made rivals green with envy if not quiver with rage. On March 12, JD(s) chief H.D. Deve Gowda gave the on-off-on-off Third Front the perfect kickstart with a massive rally attended by over three lakh people at Dobbspet, 70 km from Bangalore. Rallyists from all across the state were

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(L-R) A.B. BARDHAN, GOWDA, PRAKASH KARAT, CHANDRABABU NAIDU

ferried in 3,050 hired buses to the venue, where a 2,400-sq ft dais was built to accommodate the expected bigwigs, though some, like the AIADMK's Jayalalithaa and BSP's Mayawati, only sent representatives. Five lakh food packets were ordered from a local caterer to ensure there were no food riots. The cost of hiring the buses alone—Rs 2.5 crore. Small change when you are aiming for a second shot at prime ministership.

by Stephen David